Voices from the Lowell Mills

Lowell Offering & mill workers' letters · 1840s

Source: Lowell National Historical Park, nps.gov/lowe; Library of Congress American Memory collection.

Lowell, Massachusetts, became the model of early American factory labor in the 1820s–40s. Mill owners recruited young women from New England farms, housed them in supervised boarding houses, and paid them in cash — wages that were unusual for women at the time but low enough to keep textiles profitable. The workers founded their own literary magazine (the Lowell Offering) and later organized strikes ('turn-outs') against wage cuts and speed-ups. Their writings give us a rare first-person view of early industrial labor.

Connect: The Lowell workers used the language of the American Revolution ('we, their daughters, never will wear the yoke...') to argue against wage cuts. What does it mean for the Founders' rhetoric to be turned against American factory owners just fifty years later?

Key Passages

From the Lowell Offering

> We are willing to be called 'factory girls,' if by that name we can do anything to elevate our employment, in our own estimation, and in that of the community generally.

On a thirteen-hour day

> From five o'clock in the morning, till seven in the evening, with the intermission of half-an-hour at noon, did these tireless wheels go on. They never tired, nor lagged, nor slept; and yet we did.

From a 1834 strike circular

> Union is power. Our present object is to have union and exertion, and we remain in possession of our unquestionable rights. … As our fathers resisted unto blood the lordly avarice of the British ministry, so we, their daughters, never will wear the yoke which has been prepared for us.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Market Revolution (1820s-40s): textile mills in Lowell, Massachusetts, recruited young New England farm women, followed by wage cuts and speed-ups in the 1830s-40s.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Readers of the Lowell Offering (the public and fellow workers), family members receiving letters, and mill owners and lawmakers targeted by petitions and strikes.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Young women mill workers ('mill girls') speaking for themselves; the Offering was company-friendly, so harsher complaints appear mostly in letters and labor petitions.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HAPP — Historical Context: What was happening in the American economy in the 1830s–40s that gave these voices their political edge?

2. Compare the rhetoric of the strike circular to the language of the Declaration of Independence.

3. Identify ONE way these documents complicate a simple 'women had no voice' generalization for the era.